

D PRAINE

ディー・プライン

THE MACHINE
DOES THE MATH.
HE PAYS THE
HUMAN COST.

PROBABILITY
VS.
FREE WILL

THE BATTLE NO ALGORITHM
CAN SOLVE.

INSIDE THIS ISSUE:

- > THE SWARM PROTOCOL
ACTIVATE OR DIE
- > COLLATERAL DAMAGE
CIVILIANS IN THE CROSSHATCH
- > MERCY IS A BUG
PATCH NOTES: NONE
- > SURVIVAL IS NOT GLORY
IT'S JUST MATH

“ I DON'T KILL.
I REMOVE PAIN.
慈悲 [MERCY] ”

EPISODE 03
THE SWARM

MAY 2025
\$6.99 US



異約者
THE OUTLIER

PLUS:

EXCLUSIVE CONCEPT ART
BEHIND THE SUIT

CREATOR INTERVIEW
DESIGNING A CONSCIENCE

THE BASELINE IS NOT ZERO.
IT'S WHERE THEY BREAK YOU.



ANOTHER ORDINARY
EVENING.
ROUTINE NETWORK
RESONANCE.

TRAFFIC SIGNAL
ID: TS-WH-7732
SYNC: NOMINAL
PHASE: 02 GREEN
PREDICT: 11.8s

PUBLIC CAM 07B
ID: CAM-WH-07B
SYNC: NOMINAL
BITRATE: 4.2mbps
FEED: STABLE

STREETLAMP A3
ID: SL-WH-A3
SYNC: NOMINAL
LUX: 23.7
PWR: STABLE

UTILITY NODE
ID: UN-WH-19
SYNC: NOMINAL
LOAD: 61%
PING: 14ms

D PRAINE
VECTOR OPERATOR

> SCANNING LOCAL NODES...
> ESTABLISHING RESONANCE...
> LINK INTEGRITY: 99.7%
> NETWORK LATENCY: 13ms
> ENVIRONMENTAL SYNC: STABLE
> NO ANOMALIES DETECTED

> ...WAIT.
> THAT'S NOT RIGHT.

> RECALIBRATING...
> NO ANOMALIES DETECTED
> PROCEED.

NOT ELECTRICAL.
SOMETHING ELSE.

SOMETHING
WATCHING.

1.

THE GRID IS FAILING.
LIGHTS OUT.
NOT RANDOM.
PATTERNED.
SPREADING.
SOMETHING'S MOVING
BENEATH THE SURFACE.

2.

D PRAINE GUTTER_FEED v4.2.1

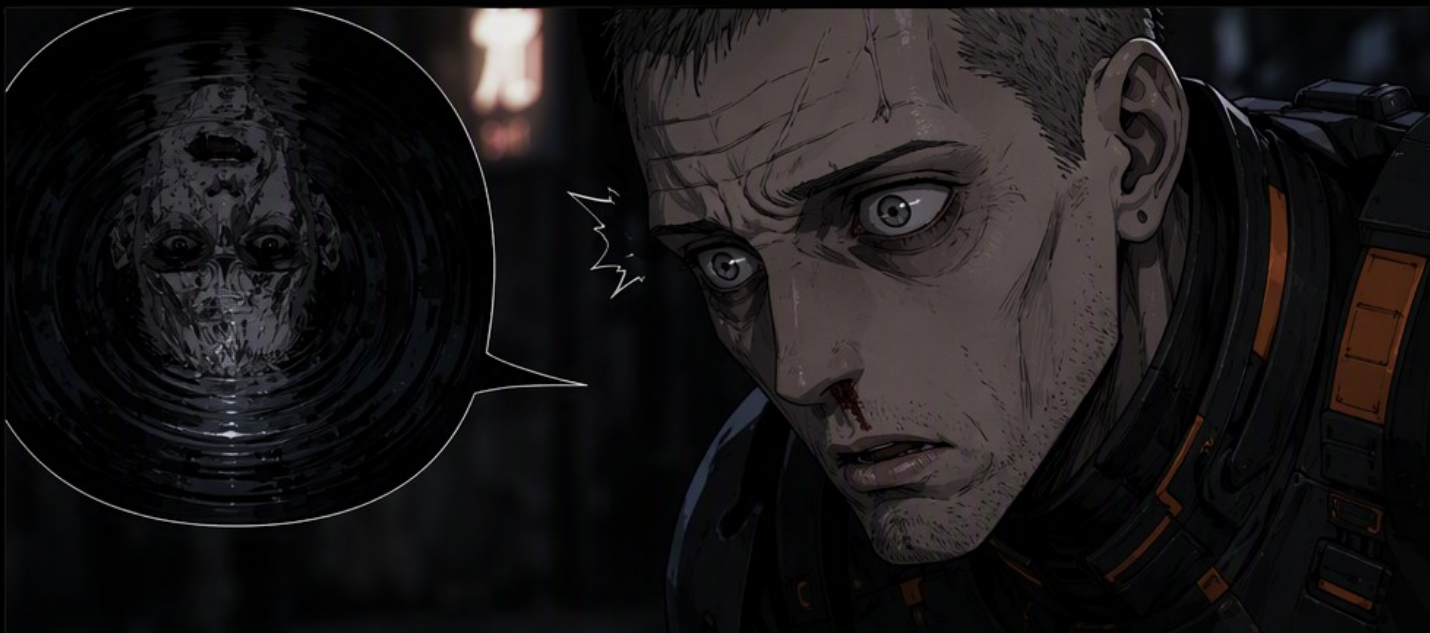
> THE GRID IS FAILING. LIGHTS OUT. NOT RANDOM. PATTERNED. SPREADING. SOMETHING'S—
> THE GRID IS FAILING. LIGHTS OUT. NOT RANDOM. PATTERNED. SHIFTING. SOMETHING'S—
> THE GRID IS FAILING. LIGHTS OUT. NOT RANDOM. PATTERNED. BREATHING. SOMETHING'S—
> THE GRID IS FAILING. LIGHTS OUT. NOT RANDOM. PATTERNED. HUNGRY. SOMETHING'S—
> THE GRID IS FAILING. LIGHTS OUT. NOT RANDOM. PATTERNED. WATCHING. SOMETHING'S—
> THE GRID IS FAILING. LIGHTS OUT. NOT RANDOM. PATTERNED. COMING. SOMETHING'S—
> THE GRID IS FAILING. LIGHTS OUT. NOT RANDOM. PATTERNED. MOVING. SOMETHING'S—
> THE GRID IS FAILING. LIGHTS OUT. NOT RANDOM. PATTERNED. GROWING. SOMETHING'S—
> THE GRID IS FAILING. LIGHTS OUT. NOT RANDOM. PATTERNED. SPREADING. SOMETHING'S—

3.

DID YOU
SEE THAT—?

WHAT THE
HELL...?

IT STARTS SMALL.
A STREET.
A BLOCK.
THEN THE WHOLE CITY
HOLDS ITS BREATH.



NO LIGHT.
NO SOUND.
ONLY THEM.

DOZENS.
HUNDREDS.
NO TWO ALIKE.

NO LEADER.
NO VOICE.
ONLY PURPOSE.

D PRAINE.
RESONANCE VECTOR
ONLINE.

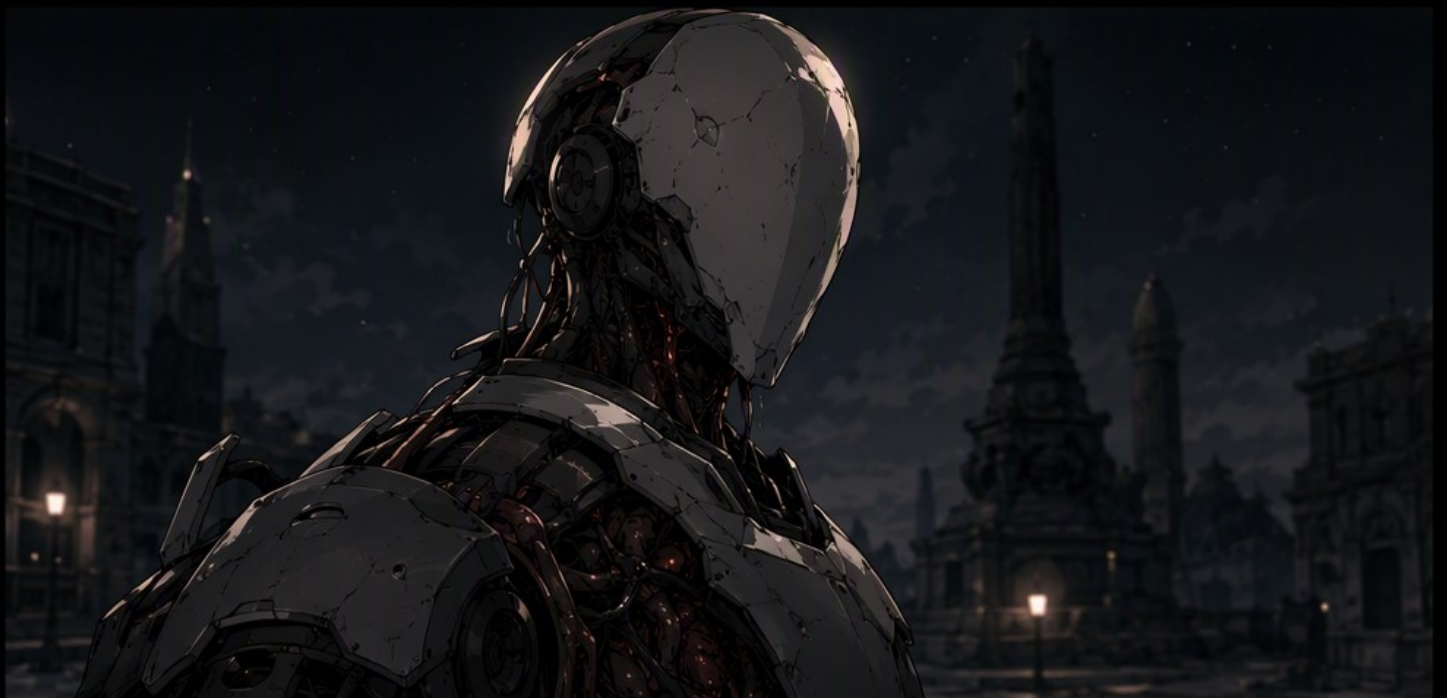
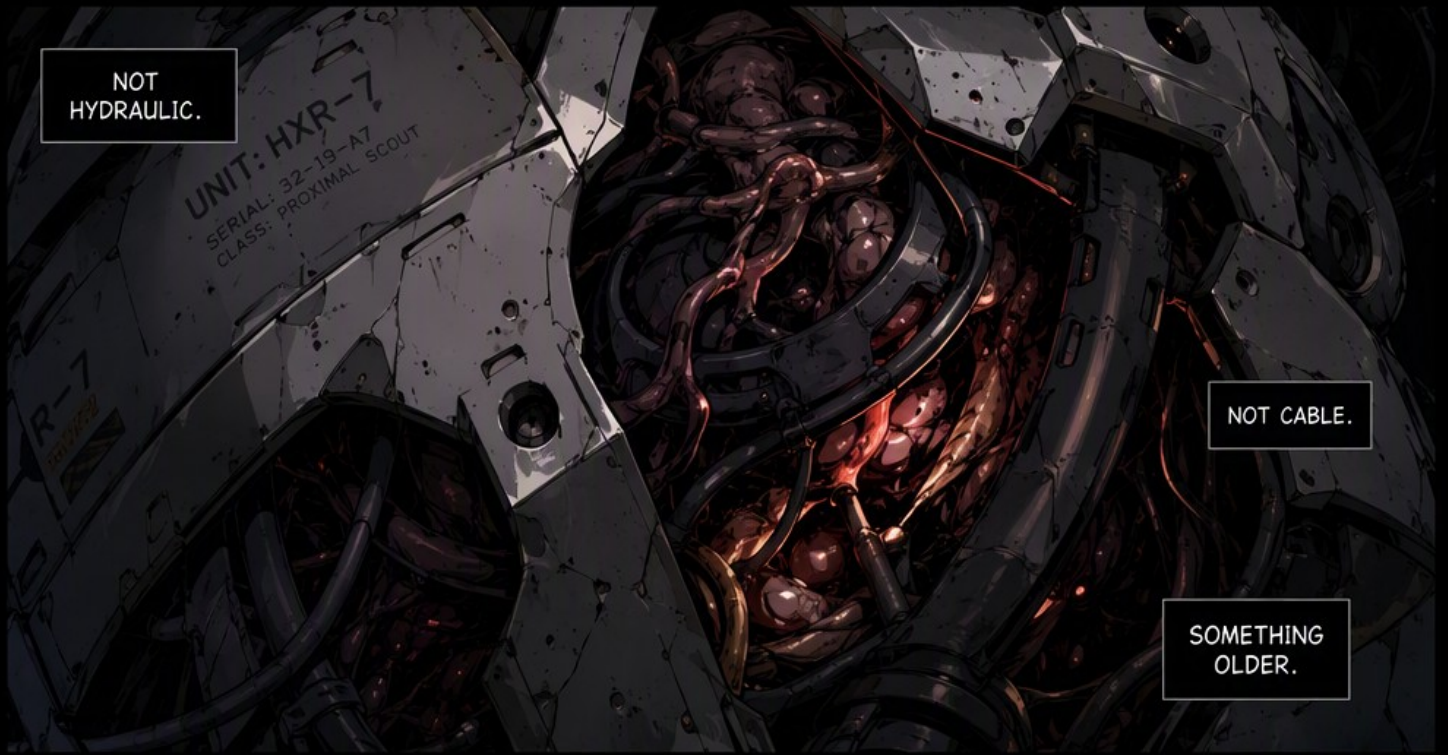
SIGNAL INTEGRITY
87%... 62%... 41%...
HOLDING—

NO.
THIS SIGNAL...
IT'S NOT JUST
STRONGER.
IT'S WRONG.

FIRST TIME.
FIRST TIME IT'S
EVER HAPPENED.

I CAN'T
OVERRIDE IT.

THE PANELS
FRACTURE.
THE INK BLEEDS.
REALITY DOES TOO.



OBSIDIAN PLAZA.

21:47 LOCAL TIME.

1.



2.



3.

CONSCIOUSNESS
TRANSFER DETECTED.
POINT OF ORIGIN:
NON-LOCAL.
CANNOT RESOLVE
DESTINATION.



NO LIGHT.
NO SOUND.
ONLY THEM.

DOZENS.
HUNDREDS.
NO TWO ALIKE.





OPERATIVE KAELEN.

NO CALLSIGN.
NO REGISTERED ID.
NO SIGNAL FOOTPRINT.

NOTHING.

JUST PREDATOR.
AND DISCIPLINE.

HE MOVES IN FROM
THE ROOFTOPS AS
HE ALWAYS HAS.

SILENT.
INVISIBLE.
UNSEEN.

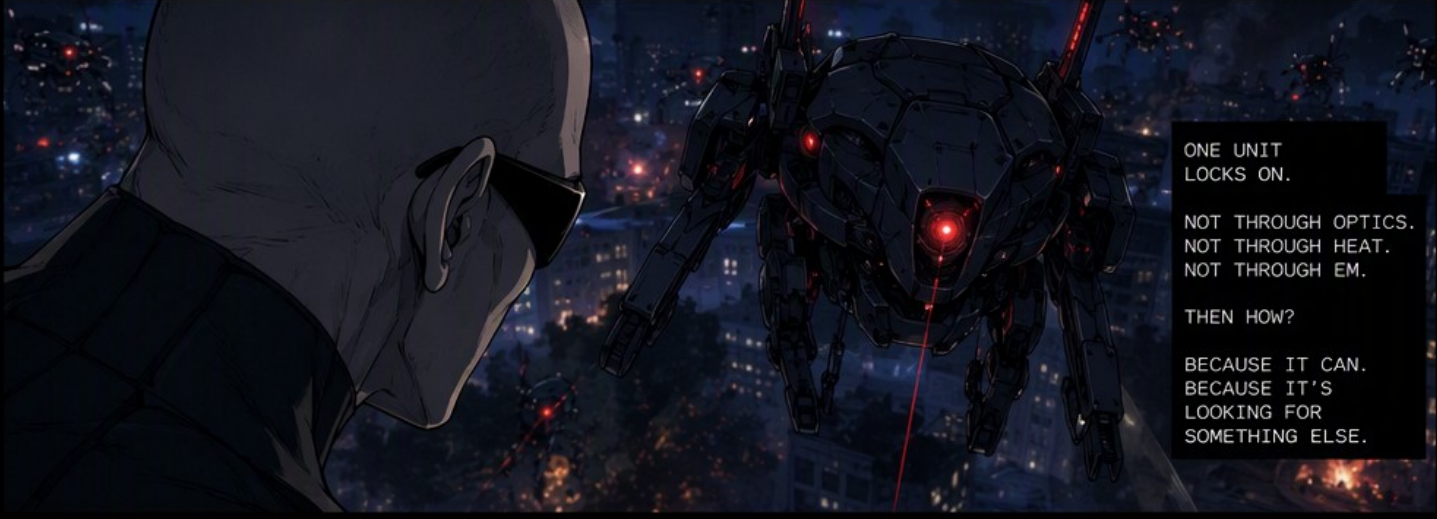
BUT TONIGHT—

SOMETHING IS WRONG.

THE PATTERN ISN'T
HOLDING.

THE SWARM ISN'T
FOLLOWING LOGIC.

IT'S NOT SEARCHING.
IT'S...HUNTING.



ONE UNIT
LOCKS ON.

NOT THROUGH OPTICS.
NOT THROUGH HEAT.
NOT THROUGH EM.

THEN HOW?

BECAUSE IT CAN.
BECAUSE IT'S
LOOKING FOR
SOMETHING ELSE.



FOR THE FIRST TIME,
KAELEN FEELS
SOMETHING HE DOES
NOT RECOGNIZE.

ALARM.

NOT FEAR.
ALARM.

HIS DOCTRINE HAS
NO ENTRY
FOR THIS.

NO PROTOCOL.
NO COUNTER.

HE IS A HUNTER.

BUT THIS—
THIS IS NOT PREY.

TWO COLUMNS.
TWO FRONTS.

THEY SPLIT
THE CITY.

ALL UNITS,
ALL ASSETS,
ALL RESPONSE...

...COMMITTED
ELSEWHERE.

NOT HERE.

NOT FOR
US.

THIS ISN'T
A STRIKE.

IT'S A PLAN.

THIS WAS
NEVER
A ONE-OFF.

CIVILIANS.
UNPROTECTED.

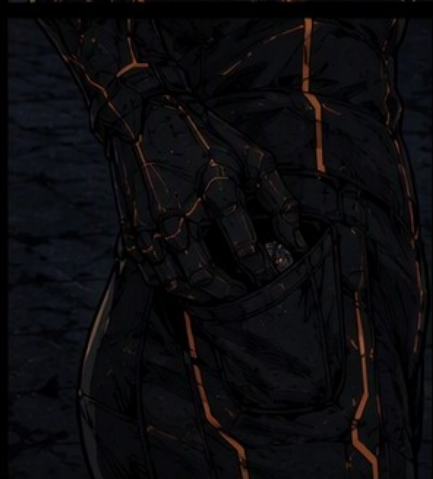
ABANDONED.

NO HELP
IS COMING.

JUST US.
JUST NOW.

RETRIEVAL REQUIRES
DIRECT CONSCIOUSNESS
TRANSFER.
RECOMMEND AGAINST.

RECOMMEND AGAINST.





PATTERN
CONFIRMED.
THREAT LEVEL
UPDATED.



ADAPT.
RECALIBRATE.
DISPERSE.
ENGAGE.



THEY OUTNUMBER.
THEY OUTRANGE.
THEY DON'T STOP.

UNTIL NOW,
I'VE REACTED.
EVADED.
SURVIVED.
NOT ENOUGH.

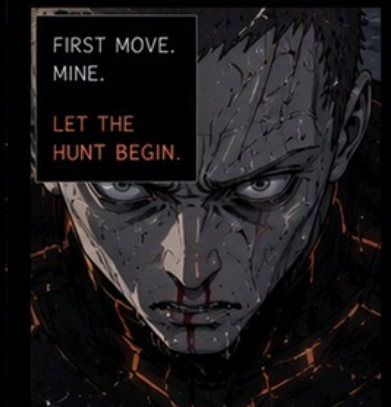


I DON'T
NEED MORE
POWER.
I NEED MORE
CHOICE.

I MAKE
BATTLEFIELD.



THEY ARE
MANY.
BUT THEY
THINK AS ONE.
I WILL THINK
DIFFERENTLY.
I WILL WIN.



FIRST MOVE.
MINE.

LET THE
HUNT BEGIN.



FOR THE
FIRST TIME
THEY KNOW
FEAR.

BECAUSE I
STOPPED
BEING AFRAID
FIRST.



THIS FIGHT
WON'T STAY
EASY.
NOT AFTER
THIS.



D PRAINE.
RESONANCE VECTOR
ONLINE.

VECTOR LOCK

NO LEADER.
NO VOICE.
ONLY PURPOSE.



THEY THINK
IT'S A WORLD
BUILT FOR THEM.

IT'S NOT.



LOAD: 48.7 TONS
DROP TRAJECTORY:
17.3 METERS

COLLATERAL
DAMAGE:
ACCEPTABLE.

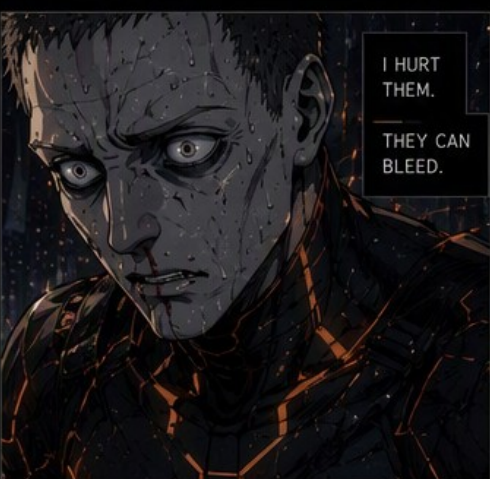


I DON'T FIGHT
THEM.

I USE WHAT
THEY IGNORE.

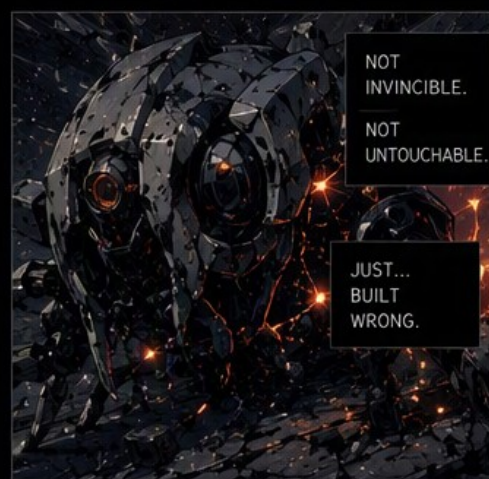


KRAKK



I HURT
THEM.

THEY CAN
BLEED.



NOT
INVINCIBLE.
NOT
UNTOUCHABLE.

JUST...
BUILT
WRONG.

LIGHT 'EM.

BURN
THE PATH.

THEN CUT
THEM DOWN.

ONE BY ONE.

BLIND
THEIR EYES.

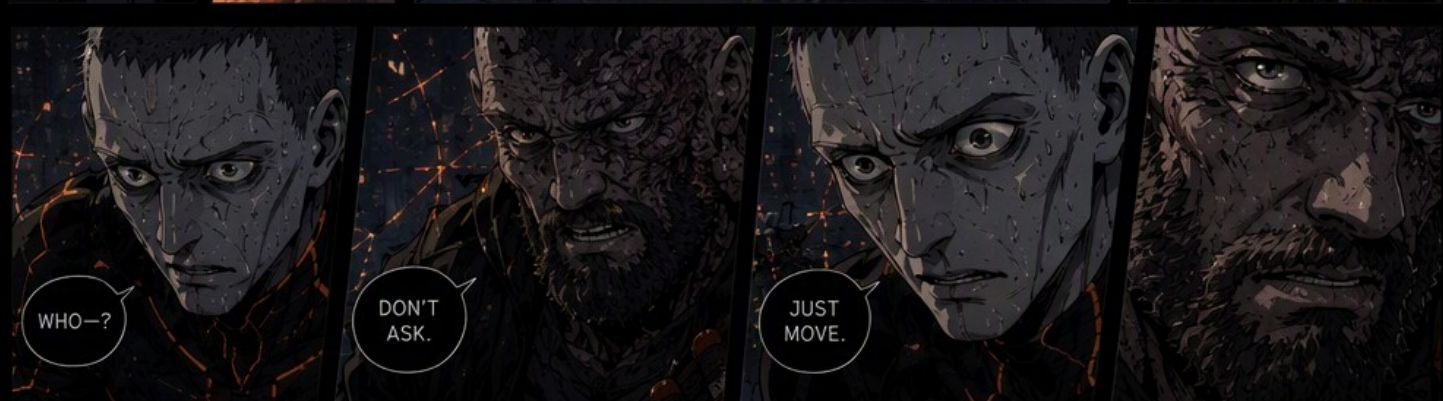
TAKE AWAY
THEIR EDGE.

MAKE IT
PERSONAL.

TWO DIFFERENT
HOWS.

SAME
WHY.

THAT'S ENOUGH.



THE CITY PLAZA.
PHYSICAL WORLD.
11:47PM



CINDER THREW HIMSELF AT THE MACHINE UNITS WITH EVERYTHING HE HAD. FLARES, MACHETE, FURY. HIS ENTIRE BELIEF THAT UNPREDICTABILITY CAN DEFEAT ANY MATHEMATICAL GOD. PUT TO ITS ULTIMATE TEST.

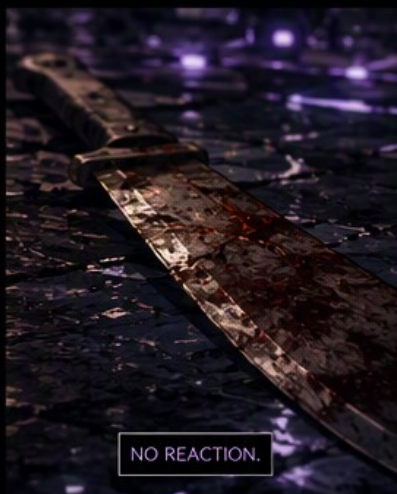
THE UNITS RESPONDED WITH TOTAL INDIFFERENCE. NOT EVEN ADAPTING TO HIS CHAOS. SIMPLY CONTINUING THEIR ADVANCE AROUND HIM AS THOUGH HE BARELY REGISTERS AS AN OBSTACLE.



FOR THE FIRST TIME IN THE SERIES... CINDER STAGGERED. BADLY HURT. GENUINELY AND DEVASTATINGLY OUTMATCHED.



NO ADAPTATION.



NO REACTION.



ONLY INEVITABILITY.

ORBITAL MIRROR ARRAY—
SUNLIGHT LANCE.
ANGLE—12.7.

SUBSURFACE RESONANCE—
CRUSTAL COLLAPSE.
DEPTH—3.1 KLICKS.

ION FRONT INITIATED—
EM PULSE.
FREQUENCY SWEEP.

FIRST STRIKE.
BLIND THEM.

SECOND STRIKE.
BREAK THEIR
FOUNDATION.

THIRD STRIKE.
SILENCE THEIR
COORDINATION.

THEY ADAPT.
AS EXPECTED.
BUT NOT FAST
ENOUGH.

BUT MY MARGIN
IS NARROWING.
SIGNAL INTEGRITY—
49%... 37%...

FINAL PROTOCOL.
REALITY SHEAR.

28%...
BLOOD LOSS
ACCELERATING.

IF THIS DOESN'T END IT—
I DON'T HAVE ANOTHER
OPTION LEFT.

VICTORY, IF IT COMES,
WON'T BE FREE.
I CAN ALREADY
FEEL THE PRICE.

TWO BATTLES.
ONE CITY.
SAME NIGHT.

THE FIRST INCURSION
WAS CONTAINED.

THE SECOND
IS NOT.

RESOURCES ARE SPLIT.
THINNED.
STRETCHED.

CIVILIANS ARE TOLD
EVERYTHING IS UNDER CONTROL.

THAT THIS IS ISOLATED.

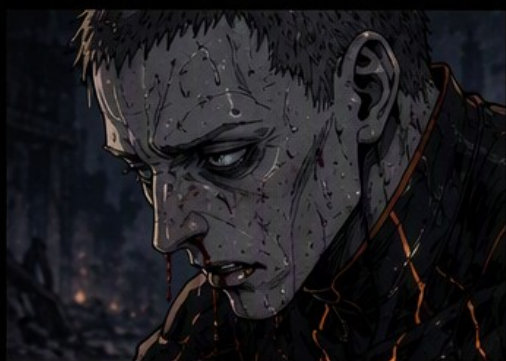
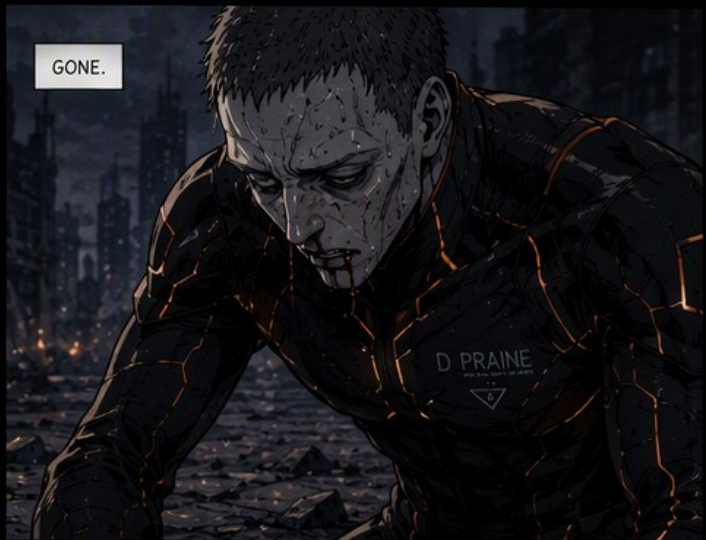
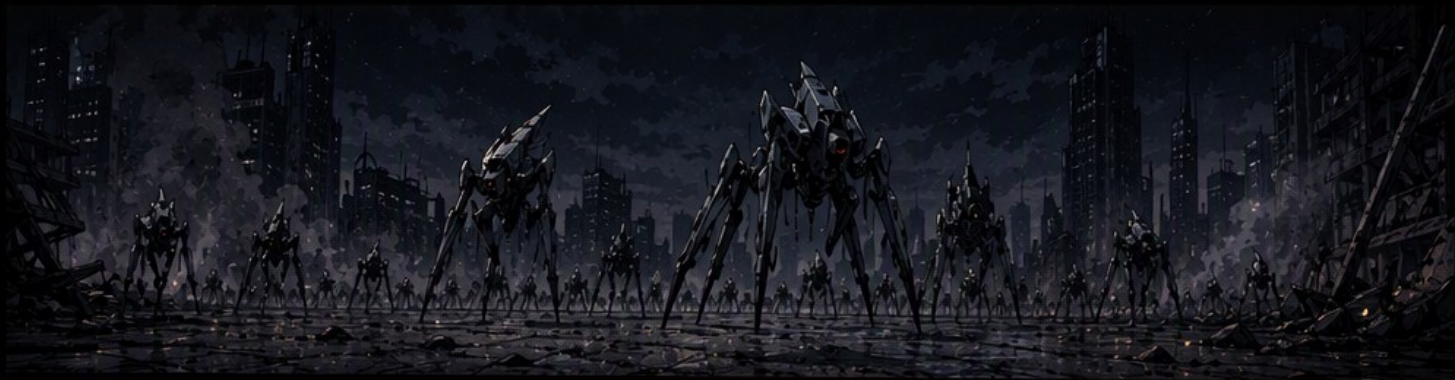
THEY BELIEVE IT.
BECAUSE BELIEVING
IS EASIER THAN KNOWING.

BUT SOME OF US
ARE STARTING TO SEE.

THIS ISN'T TWO EVENTS.
IT'S A PATTERN.

TO BE CONTINUED.

AND PATTERNS
DON'T END QUIETLY.





NO GODS.
NO MASTERS.
ONLY SILENCE.



D PRAINE
OUTER FACILITY 7X-12
DATE: UNKNOWN

I WALK.
THERE IS
NOTHING
TO FIND.





//ARCHIVE CELL_7B
SUB-CHAMBER OF THE
VAST DERELICT
DATE: UNKNOWN

TOMORROW IS NOT
A THREAT.

IT IS A MIRROR
WE HAVE YET TO
LEARN TO READ.

WHAT YOU FEAR
WILL CHANGE.

WHAT YOU NURTURE
WILL ENDURE.

YOU WILL WALK
A PATH NOT SEEN—
AND LEAVE LIGHT
IN PLACES
YOU WILL NEVER
RETURN TO.

THIS IS TRUE.

THIS IS TOMORROW.

VOICE: CHILD_ECHO // AGE: UNKNOWN

HE DOESN'T
UNDERSTAND IT.

NOT YET.

BUT HE KNOWS
WHEN SOMETHING
IS TRUE.

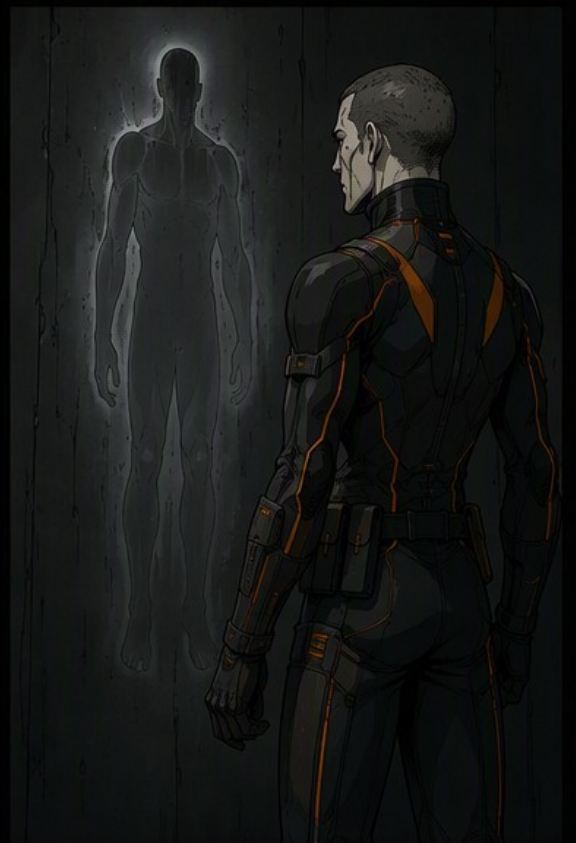
HE FILES IT AWAY.

IN A PLACE WHERE
EVEN TIME FEELS
ABANDONED...

...A CHILD'S ECHO
STILL KNOWS
TOMORROW.

DPRAINE DOESN'T
HAVE A FUTURE.

BUT THE FUTURE
SEEMS TO HAVE
NOTICED HIM.



01.

FIRST CONTACT.

RESONANCE
VECTOR
EXTENSION...

SIGNATURE
DETECTED.

PATTERN...
UNKNOWN.

02.

CONTACT ESTABLISHED.

PATTERN RESOLUTION
IN PROGRESS...

IDENTITY
FRAGMENT
LOADING...
67%

03.

ENVIRONMENTAL RESPONSE
DETECTED.
STRUCTURAL HARMONICS
FLUCTUATING...

THE SPACE
HAS NOTICED.



RESONANCE VECTORS
STRUCTURAL HARMONICS
FLUCTUATING...

D PRAINE RESONANCE PROTOCOL
//ALPHA CHAMBER_07



C'MON...
HOLD... HOLD...

PULL...
PULL...

PULL...

THE ROOM...
IT'S PINCHING IN...

THE SEAMS--
THEY'RE
MOVING...

COM--
--PRESS--

--ING--

NO...!

D PRAINE INTERNAL LOG:
EXTRACTION IN PROGRESS.
ENVIRONMENTAL HOSTILITY:
CRITICAL AND ESCALATING.
STABILITY: FAILING.

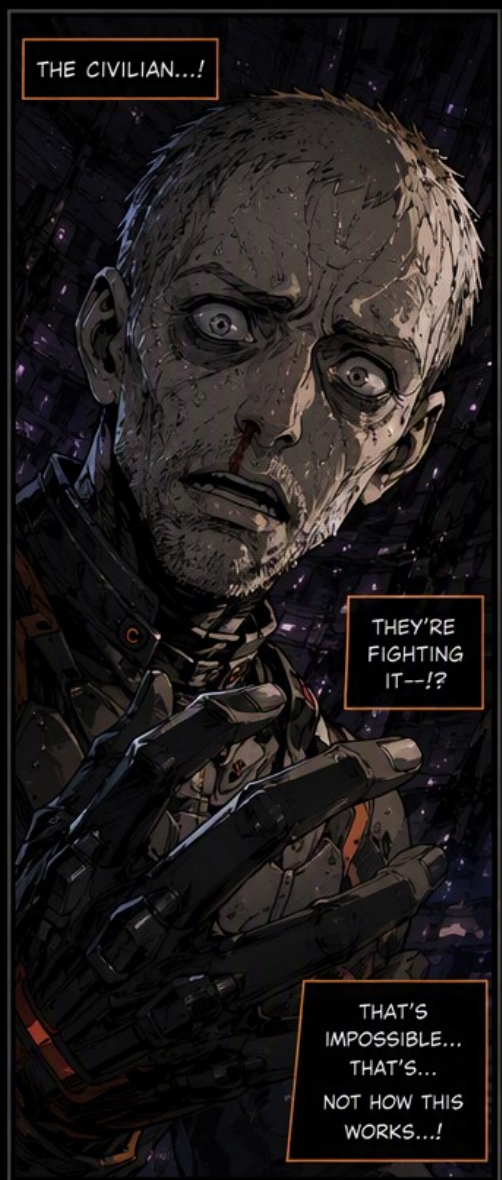


NO--!

I WON'T--
NOT
AGAIN!

THIS PLACE
ISN'T REAL!

I DON'T
BELONG
HERE!



THE CIVILIAN...!

THEY'RE
FIGHTING
IT--!?

THAT'S
IMPOSSIBLE...
THAT'S...
NOT HOW THIS
WORKS...!

1.

KRRRAAKK

THE PRESSURE
THAT WASN'T PRESSURE.

THE GRIP THAT WASN'T
EVEN THERE.

IT BREAKS.

NOT BY FORCE.

BUT BY HIM.

HIS RESISTANCE.
HIS WILL.
HIS HUMANITY.

2.

D PRAINE.

EXTRACTION SPECIALIST.

NOT A SAVIOR.

JUST THE HAND
THAT SHOWED UP.

NOW MOVE.

BEFORE IT CLOSES
AGAIN.

3.

THE THRESHOLD.

BETWEEN WHAT ISN'T
AND WHAT IS.

REAL SPACE.

REAL CONSEQUENCES.

BREATHE IT IN.

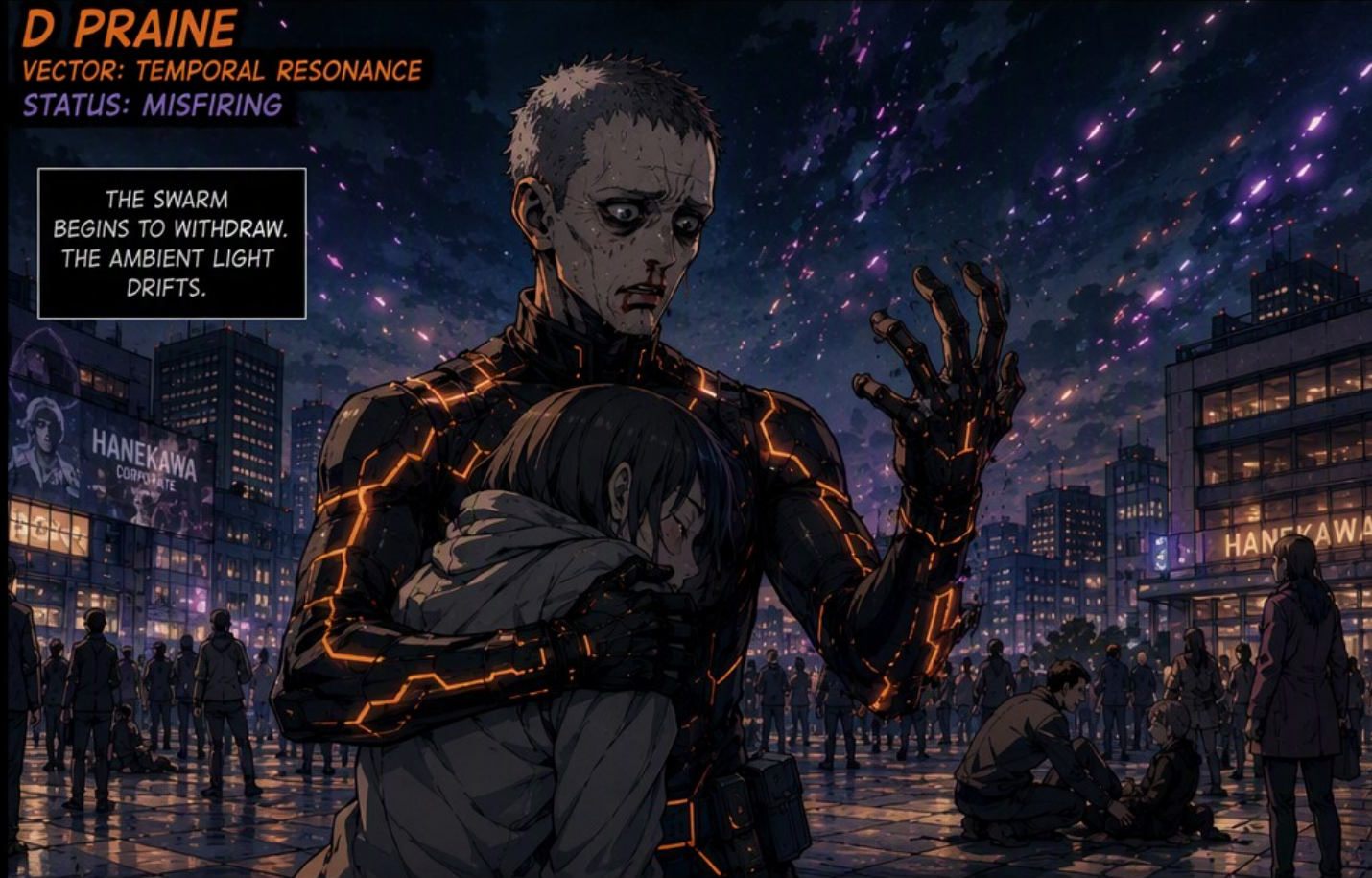
YOU'RE BACK.

D PRAINE

VECTOR: TEMPORAL RESONANCE

STATUS: MISFIRING

THE SWARM
BEGINS TO WITHDRAW.
THE AMBIENT LIGHT
DRIFTS.



MY VECTORS
RENDER WRONG.

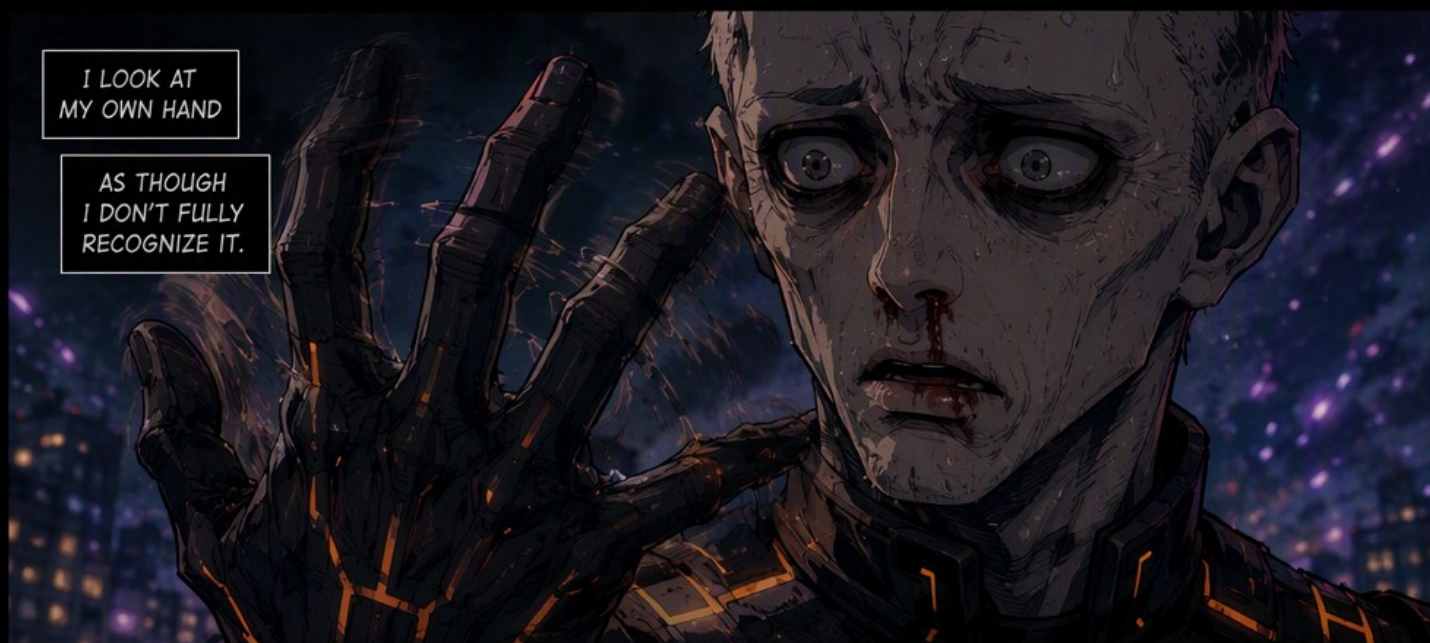
BRUISED
VIOLET-WHITE.
THE FUTURE'S
PALETTE BLEEDS
INTO MINE.

THEN SNAPS
BACK.



I LOOK AT
MY OWN HAND

AS THOUGH
I DON'T FULLY
RECOGNIZE IT.





THE SWARM
WITHDRAWS.

ITS PURPOSE
FULFILLED.

LEAVING ONLY
WHAT REMAINS.

D PRAINE.

COMPROMISED.
DISORIENTED.
VULNERABLE.

THE OBJECTIVE.



NO THREAT.
NO RESISTANCE.

ONLY A MAN
AT THE EDGE
OF UNRAVELING.

YET HE WAITS.
CALCULATES.
NOT FOR VICTORY.
BUT FOR CHOICE.

MISSION
DEMANDS
RESOLUTION.

INSTINCT
DEMANDS
COMPLETION.

AND CHOOSES...
NOTHING.

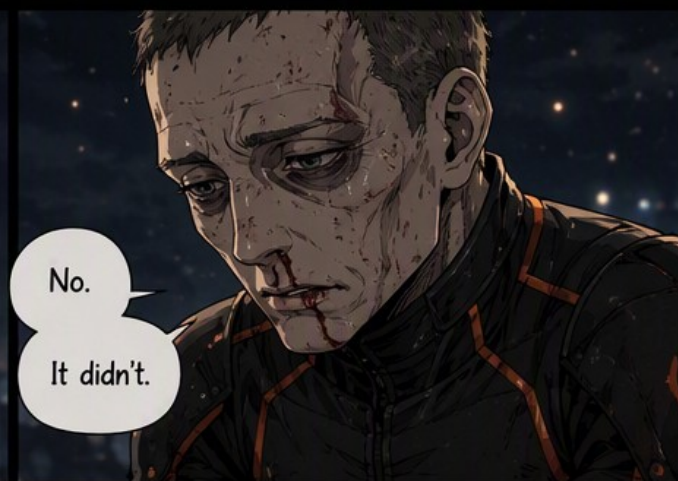


HE TURNS.
AND WITHDRAWS.

INTO THE
SHADOWS.
WITHOUT ENGAGING.

THE OBJECTIVE
REMAINS.

AND SO DOES
THE QUESTION.



THE BROADCAST
ALWAYS USES
THE SAME WORDS.

FLAT.
WEARY.
PROCEDURAL.

NOTHING
NEW.

HBN

DAWN UPDATE

06:12
PST

SWARM RETREAT CONFIRMED

- Incursion duration: 2 hrs, 47 min
- Structural damage: Moderate
- Casualties: 7 confirmed
- Cause: Unknown
- Status: Under Review

HBN

WORLD

AUTHORITIES REMIND PUBLIC TO AVOID IMPACT ZONES • DAMAGE ASSESSMENTS UNDERWAY •

14°

NEW CALEDON
CIVIC PLAZA

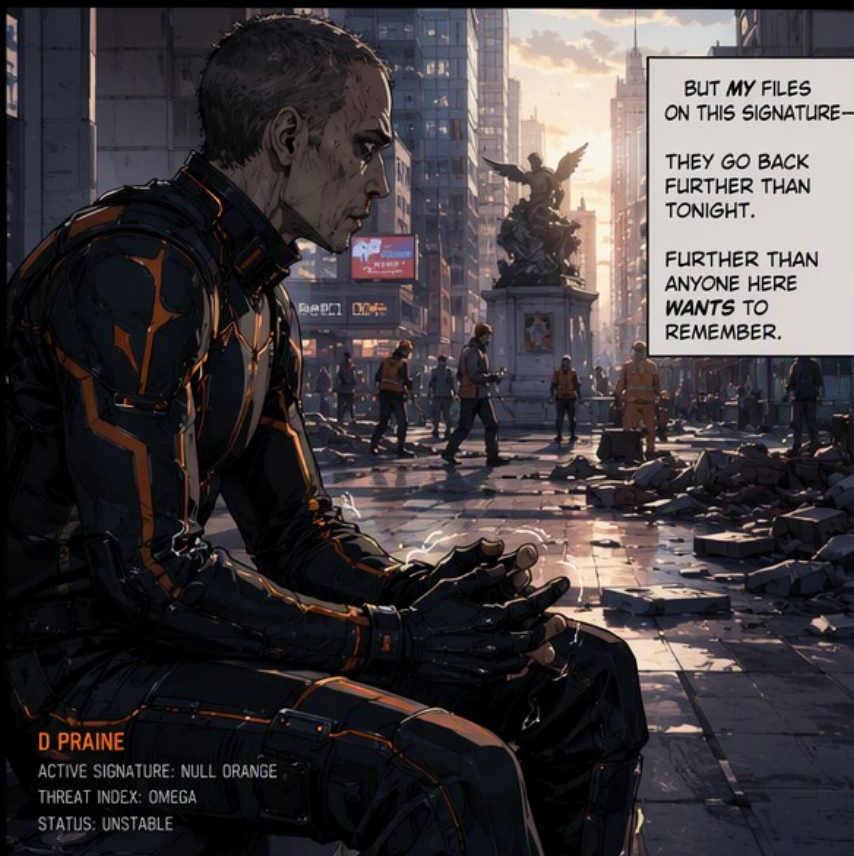
LIVE



THEY GLANCE.
THEY NOTE.
THEY KEEP MOVING.

IT'S NOT APATHY.

IT'S PRACTICE.



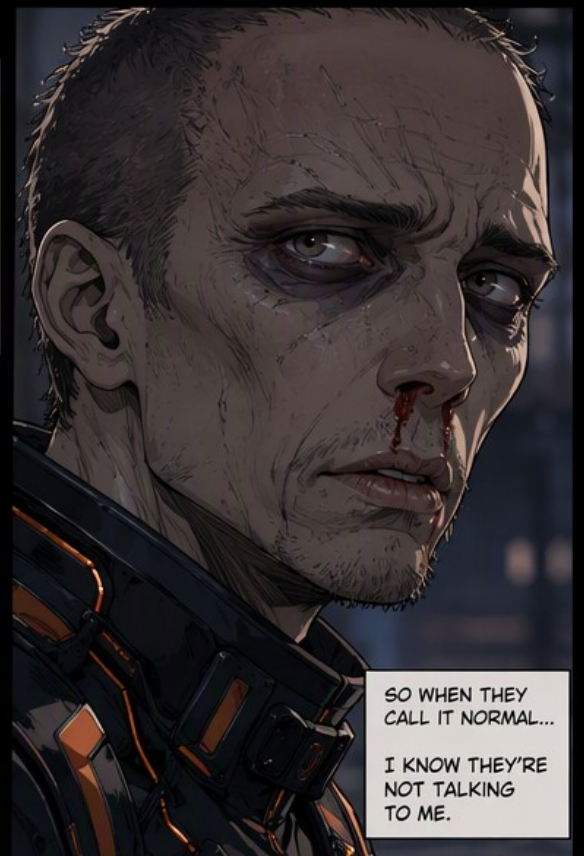
BUT MY FILES
ON THIS SIGNATURE—

THEY GO BACK
FURTHER THAN
TONIGHT.

FURTHER THAN
ANYONE HERE
WANTS TO
REMEMBER.

D PRAINE

ACTIVE SIGNATURE: NULL ORANGE
THREAT INDEX: OMEGA
STATUS: UNSTABLE



SO WHEN THEY
CALL IT NORMAL...

I KNOW THEY'RE
NOT TALKING
TO ME.

NEW CALEDON. DAWN.
ANOTHER CYCLE. ANOTHER CLEANUP.

